Forum:	Social, Humanitarian and Cultural Committee (GA3)
Issue:	Combating honour-based abuse and killings and ensuring the protection of victims
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Position:	Co-Chair

Personal Introduction

Dear delegates of the Social, Humanitarian and Cultural Committee,

I am Marilou Komninou, a 10th-grade pupil at the German School of Athens (DSA), and I am honoured to be your Co-Chair in this year's MoMUN Conference. By the time of the Conference, I will have attended five Conferences as a delegate and one as a Chair, and I am hoping that we will have a great time and MUN experience. Personally, I think that you should continue pursuing your MUN career since it may help you manage social anxiety, offer you knowledge on topics you never would have imagined were important and interesting, and open many doors for you in the future. MUN teaches you diplomacy and conversation skills and allows you to understand the value of decision-making.

The topic of this study guide, namely "Combating honour-based abuse and killings and ensuring the protection of victims," is such an important topic since it acknowledges the difficulties, the abuse, and the violence some victims go through. This is an opportunity for you, as representatives of different nations, to take action in a representation of the real United Nations, which offers you a scaled-down simulation of global diplomacy. All this action being taken by young people shows that there is still hope that diplomacy will continue to exist in the future and will hopefully spread to other parts of the world that currently lack opportunities for diplomatic dialogue.

If you have any questions regarding the topic, MUN, the conference, or generally a question that I am able to help you with, please do not hesitate to reach out via email at kommarilou@gmail.com. Also, this is the email of your Main Chair, Ioanna Maria Ziakka, ioannaziakka@gmail.com.

Kind regards,

Marilou Komninou

Introduction

Honour-based abuse refers to violence, coercion or control intended to uphold a family's or community's perceived honour. It may include one or multiple perpetrators close to the victim, such as family members, extended relatives, or community members. It includes emotional and psychological abuse, threats or intimidation, forced marriage, financial control, as well as physical

violence. Murder ("honour-based killings"), stalking and surveillance, sexual violence, and restriction on social life, education, work, friendships, or the choice of partner are also considered typical forms of honour-based abuse. Victims are most commonly women and girls, but men and boys can also be targeted, including LGBTQ+ individuals. Perpetrators may target victims who do not conform to conservative gender norms in their family or community. Such examples would be victims who may have refused to be a part of an arranged marriage, might be seeking a divorce, or even be refusing to marry in general. Certain victims are members of the LGBTQ+ community, which may not align with the beliefs of a patriarchal family or community, and may therefore expose them to the risk of honour-based abuse and killings.[1, 2, 3]

Victims may face retaliation for reporting honour-based abuse to the authorities or for behaviour considered unacceptable by a controlling household.

Some warning signs help specialists identify honour-based abuse or a risk of serious violence. Such signs may be that the victims may face sudden restrictions, while also being monitored by their relatives, and develop a fear of leaving the supposedly "safe place", or of being taken abroad, and may withdraw from the educational system, their work positions, and their social lives. Victims may be made to feel that they bring "shame" to the family and may be isolated.

Key Terms and Definitions

Honour-based abuse (HBA)

Honour-based abuse involves violence, threats, intimidation, coercion or other abuse committed, or potentially committed, to protect an individual's, family's or community's perceived honour following alleged breaches of its code of behaviour.[4]

Honour-based violence (HBV)

It is a form of violence often associated with patriarchal beliefs. Victims and perpetrators may belong to close-knit social groups and communities. It may involve collective efforts to uphold a family's perceived image and prestige or to punish a victim's choices.[5]

[1] Crown Prosecution Service. (n.d.). Honour-based abuse. https://www.cps.gov.uk/types-crime/violence-against-women-and-girls/honour-based-abuse

[2] Safer Ealing. (2023, November 27). So called honour-based abuse. https://saferealing.co.uk/so-called-honour-based-abuse/

[3] Radford, L., Gill, A., Burrows, S., & Bone, J. (2004). Moving forward on prevention: Domestic violence and community safety in West Sussex. https://knowledge.lancashire.ac.uk/id/eprint/6124/1/TN30%20-%20DV%20and%20CS%20in%20WS%20-%20Roehampton%20Report.pdf

[4] Crown Prosecution Service. (n.d.). Honour-based abuse. https://www.cps.gov.uk/types-crime/violence-against-women-and-girls/honour-based-abuse

[5] Crown Prosecution Service. (n.d.). Honour-based abuse. https://www.cps.gov.uk/types-crime/violence-against-women-and-girls/honour-based-abuse

Coercive control

It is a pattern of abusive behaviour used to dominate another person and exercise power over them. When a member of a family becomes restrictive and controlling, this may also constitute domestic abuse.[6]

Domestic abuse

Under the Domestic Abuse Act 2021 in England and Wales, domestic abuse is abusive behaviour between people who are each aged 16 or over and personally connected. It includes physical, sexual, psychological, emotional and economic abuse, as well as controlling, coercive, violent or threatening behaviour. It may involve a partner, former partner, spouse or relative.[7]

Family violence

Family violence refers to a pattern of abuse by a family member or intimate partner towards another to establish or uphold power. It includes physical violence, emotional violence, sexual abuse, and in some cases economic control. Family violence can affect anyone regardless of their background and is often characterised as a situation that causes fear and harm to the victim. It is important to recognise that family violence does not only affect and concern low-income families or certain ethnic groups since it can occur in households of all socioeconomic groups.[8]

(Traditional) Harmful practices

Harmful practices are a form of discrimination that violates human rights and are deeply ingrained customs and beliefs that persist in societies due to cultural, social, or religious norms, often reflecting gender inequality and power imbalances between men and women. Women and young girls are disproportionately affected due to gender inequality. Examples of harmful traditional practices include child marriage, female genital mutilation, bride kidnapping, etc. Other forms of abuse include restrictions on education and so-called "corrective" violence.[9]

Coercion

Coercion is the use of force to persuade someone to do something that they are unwilling to do. In this context, the word coercion is used to explain that victims are forced to follow beliefs that don't

[6] Lamothe, C. (2019, October 10). Coercive control: 12 Signs and how to get out. Healthline. https://www.healthline.com/health/coercive-control

[7] Domestic Abuse Act 2021, c. 17, §§ 1–3 (UK). https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/2021/17/contents

[8] Center Against Sexual and Family Violence. (n.d.). What is family violence? https://casfv.org/what-is-abuse/what-is-family-violence

[9] Gender and Development Network. (n.d.). Harmful traditional practices: Your questions, our answers. https://had-int.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/04/GADN-Harmful-Traditional-Practice.pdf

align with their own and have to adapt to such beliefs and values so they avoid facing consequences that will be inflicted by their own family or community.[10]

Patriarchal

Patriarchal describes a social system in which men hold a disproportionately large share of social, economic, political and religious power. The term relates to patriarchy, or rule by the father; inheritance may pass through the male line, although this is not a universal feature.[11]

Forced and arranged marriage

Forced and arranged marriages are distinct. In an arranged marriage between adults, families may help choose a partner, but both prospective spouses freely consent. A forced marriage occurs when one or both people do not or cannot consent and coercion is used where required by law. In England and Wales, causing anyone under 18 to marry is also an offence even without coercion. Family involvement in choosing partners occurs in many societies and has historically served purposes such as forming alliances and maintaining family ties.[12]

Honour

Honour is a universal concept, but its meaning, value, and applications are variable historically and culturally. Also, not a single community, culture, or class has a monopoly on defending one's honour through violence. Perceived threats to honour have been used to justify acts of horrific violence.[13]

Background Information

Historical Background

Patriarchal systems have existed for a very long time. Ancient Mesopotamian legal traditions, including Sumerian law and the much later Middle Assyrian laws, regulated women's sexual conduct. The Middle Assyrian laws, preserved in a compilation dated to around 1075 BC, imposed severe penalties on women but also punished men in some circumstances. Later, the Roman Twelve Tables, traditionally composed in 451–450 BC and ratified in 449 BC, codified paternal power and women's guardianship. They do not establish a general right for all male relatives to kill women

[10] Cambridge University Press. (n.d.). Coercion. In Cambridge dictionary. Retrieved October 29, 2026, from https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/english/coercion

[11] Merriam-Webster. (n.d.). Patriarchal. In Merriam-Webster.com dictionary. Retrieved October 29, 2026, from https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/patriarchal

[12] Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office, & Home Office. (n.d.). Multi-agency statutory guidance for dealing with forced marriage and multi-agency practice guidelines: Handling cases of forced marriage. GOV.UK. https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/the-right-to-choose-government-guidance-on-forced-marriage

[13] Bhanbhro, S. (2023). Stalking and coercive control: Commonly used strategies in honour-based abuse against young people. In Young people, stalking awareness and domestic abuse (pp. 141–159). Springer. https://shura.shu.ac.uk/32794/

merely suspected of sexual transgressions. Practices relating family reputation to women's conduct have also been reported across Mediterranean Europe, the Middle East and South Asia.[14, 15]

Women have faced many different forms of gender-based violence, including stoning, beheading, throat slashing, acid attacks, head shaving, facial mutilation and female genital mutilation (FGM). These practices have different histories and cannot all be classified as honour-based abuse without examining their context. Stoning has been used as a public punishment for alleged sexual transgressions, although the practices and legal traditions involved vary. Beheading and throat slashing have also been reported in killings justified by perpetrators in terms of family honour. Acid attacks cause severe pain and disfigurement when corrosive substances are thrown onto a victim's body or face; perpetrators may intend to humiliate or control the victim. Head shaving and facial mutilation, including cutting off the nose or ears, have likewise been used to punish or publicly shame people. FGM is associated in some communities with attempts to control female sexuality and promote premarital virginity and marital fidelity; it does not guarantee fidelity and has no health benefits.[16, 17, 18, 19]

Honour-based *abuse and killings over the years*

Recorded honour-based abuse cases have increased in some datasets, but this does not establish a corresponding increase in the underlying incidence of abuse or killings. According to a 2021 report based on freedom of information requests answered by 28 of 39 constabularies, recorded HBA cases rose from 884 in 2016 to 1,599 in 2020, an increase of approximately 81%. These figures included offences such as rape, death threats and assault. More victims coming forward and changes in police recording can affect reported totals, while underreporting obscures the scale of the issue. Imran Khodabocus, then a senior associate at the Family Law Company, argued in that report that COVID-

[14] Internet History Sourcebooks Project. (1998). The code of the Assura, c. 1075 BCE. Fordham University. https://sourcebooks.fordham.edu/ancient/1075assyriancode.asp

[15] Johnson, A. C., Coleman-Norton, P. R., & Bourne, F. C. (1961). The Twelve Tables. In Ancient Roman statutes. University of Texas Press. https://avalon.law.yale.edu/ancient/twelve_tables.asp

[16] Government of Canada. (2013, September 24). Introduction - preliminary examination of so-called honour killings in Canada. Department of Justice Canada. https://www.justice.gc.ca/eng/rp-pr/cj-jp/fv-vf/hk-ch/p1.html

[17] Gevangenpoort. (n.d.). Punishments were truly horrible in the Middle Ages. https://gevangenpoort.nl/en/explore/stories-about-crime-and-punishment/punishments-were-truly-horrible-in-the-middle-ages/

[18] World Health Organization. (n.d.). Female genital mutilation. https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/female-genital-mutilation

[19] Women's Voices Now. (2025, July 22). Honor violence: A hidden war on women. https://www.womensvoicesnow.org/honor-violence

19 lockdowns had worsened the problem for some victims and anticipated further reports as restrictions eased.[20, 21, 22]

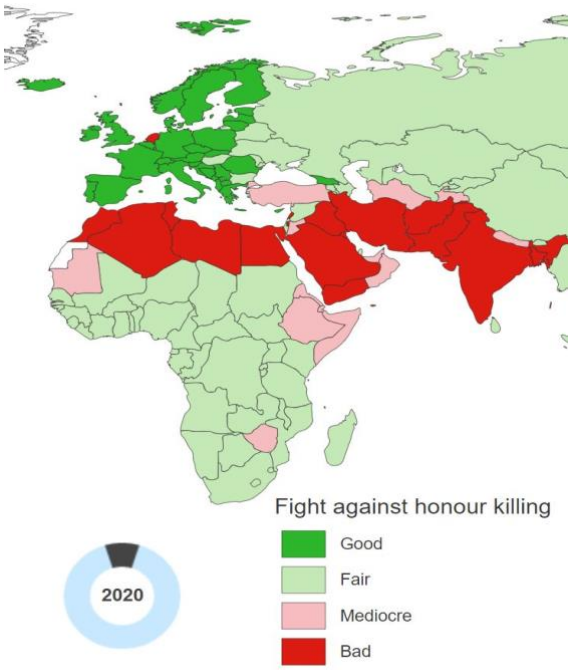


Fig. 1: Campaign ratings of the fight against honour killing in 2020 (Source: No Honor in Killing; these are not counts of killings).[23]

Safety challenges in the former attempts to solve the issue

In the past, victims found it difficult to report honour-based abuse and killings to the authorities or seek assistance, for multiple reasons. Reported barriers include inadequate training among some authorities and uncertainty among victims about whether seeking assistance will improve their safety.[24]

[20] Home Office. (2025, November 6). Statistics on so called 'honour-based' abuse offences, England and Wales, year ending March 2025. GOV.UK. https://www.gov.uk/government/statistics/so-called-honour-based-abuse-offences-year-ending-march-2025/statistics-on-so-called-honour-based-abuse-offences-england-and-wales-year-ending-march-2025

[21] Siddique, H. (2021, October 31). 'Honour-based' offences soared by 81% in last five years. The Guardian. https://www.theguardian.com/society/2021/oct/31/honour-based-offences-soared-by-81-in-last-five-years

[22] Siddique, H. (2021, October 31). 'Honour-based' offences soared by 81% in last five years. The Guardian. https://www.theguardian.com/society/2021/oct/31/honour-based-offences-soared-by-81-in-last-five-years

[23] No Honor in Killing. (n.d.). Interactive world map: Fight against honour killing 2010–2020. https://nohonor.org/interactive-world-map-fight-against-honour-killing-2010-2020/

[24] Hull, J., & Hibbert, S. (2023, May 17). Honour-based abuse: Why it must become a priority. Crest Advisory. https://www.crestadvisory.com/post/honour-based-abuse-why-it-must-become-a-priority

Safety challenges include victims' fear of retaliation against themselves or supportive relatives, financial dependence on their families, and concerns about community stigma or ostracism. These obstacles can prevent victims from reporting abuse to the authorities and help explain why the exact number of cases remains unknown.[25]

How honour-based abuse and killings happen

Honour-based abuse and killings may involve a pattern of violence and control. Perpetrators may react to actions such as victims expressing their concerns or asserting their own beliefs. Relatives or others close to the victims may then trigger judgemental discussions within the social group. Families who perceive themselves as exposed to dishonour or shame may restrict victims' freedom and closely monitor their actions. Victims may develop fear of these individuals, and the abuse may escalate to serious violence or killing. This is a possible pattern, rather than a fixed sequence followed in every case.

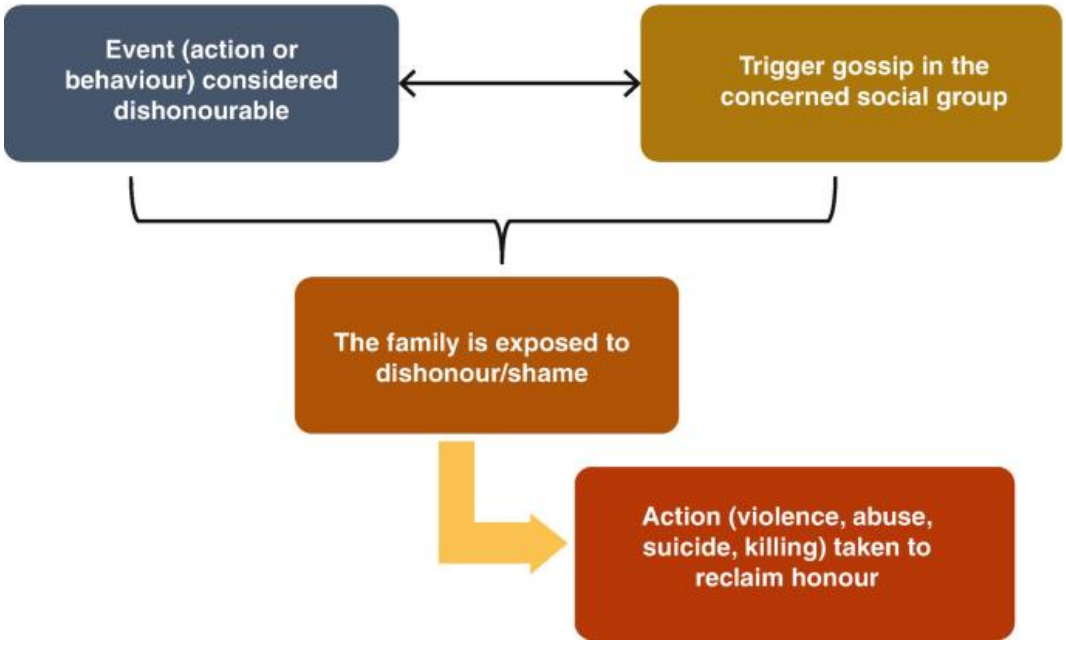


Fig. 2: An illustrative model of honour-based abuse and escalation (Source: Stalking and coercive control; perceived dishonour reflects perpetrators' beliefs).[26]

Causes and consequences of honour-based abuse and killings

Victims can be targeted for many reasons, particularly women and girls whose activities are closely monitored in patriarchal societies.

[25] Women and Equalities Committee. (2023, July 19). So-called honour-based abuse (HC 831). House of Commons. https://publications.parliament.uk/pa/cm5803/cmselect/cmwomeq/831/report.html

[26] Bhanbhro, S. (2023). Stalking and coercive control: Commonly used strategies in honour-based abuse against young people. In Young people, stalking awareness and domestic abuse (pp. 141–159). Springer. https://shura.shu.ac.uk/32794/

Perpetrators' stated justifications for honour-based abuse or killing vary, ranging from perceived breaches of "sexual purity" before marriage to a victim's gender identity, change of religion or refusal to follow family expectations. These factors in certain backgrounds can be perceived by perpetrators as making the family feel "embarrassed" or dishonoured.[27]

Choices accepted in many societies may expose victims to severe retaliation in others. As victims' lives are closely monitored, they are often prevented from socialising, and in many cases, they suffer from bodily harm, as well as being mistreated and neglected. In some extreme cases, the victim might also be killed by a perpetrator.[28]

Case Studies

The Murder of Farzana Parveen

In 2014, an honour-based killing took place in Pakistan, where a 25-year-old pregnant woman named Farzana Parveen was beaten to death by relatives because she had married the man of her choice. On 27 May, she and her husband were approaching the Lahore High Court in Punjab to contest an abduction complaint brought by her father. According to the account recorded by UN Special Procedures, relatives and other people stopped them near the court, and a brother struck her head with a brick. Her husband survived the attack. Her father was arrested and reportedly admitted killing her because he disapproved of the marriage, expressing no regret. Reports described a large group of relatives and others waiting outside the court and attempting to separate her from her husband.[29, 30, 31, 32]

The UN Special Procedures documented the case as an alleged killing in the name of "honour" and raised concerns about the failure of authorities to protect the victim from such a brutal death, even outside of such a respected building like the Lahore High Court.[33]

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[27] Khan, R. (2024). The psychology of honor abuse, violence, and killings. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/385116654_The_Psychology_of_Honor_Abuse_Violence_and_Killings

[28] State of Victoria. (2021, July 21). Presentations of family violence in different relationships and communities. https://www.vic.gov.au/maram-practice-guides-foundation-knowledge-guide/presentations-family-violence-different-relationships-and-communities

[29] United Nations Special Procedures. (2014, June 5). Communication PAK 9/2014 concerning Farzana Parveen. Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights. https://spcommreports.ohchr.org/TmSearch/RelCom?code=PAK%209%2F2014

[30] Al Jazeera. (2014, May 28). Pakistan woman stoned by family outside court. https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2014/5/28/pakistan-woman-stoned-by-family-outside-court

[31] Al Jazeera. (2014, May 28). Pakistan woman stoned by family outside court. https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2014/5/28/pakistan-woman-stoned-by-family-outside-court

[32] Al Jazeera. (2014, May 28). Pakistan woman stoned by family outside court. https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2014/5/28/pakistan-woman-stoned-by-family-outside-court

[33] UN News. (2014, May 28). UN rights chief urges action after pregnant Pakistani woman stoned to death by family. UN News. https://news.un.org/en/story/2014/05/469432

The Murder of Rania Alayed

Rania Alayed was a 25-year-old woman of Palestinian origin who grew up in Syria and had faced violence from a very young age. Having been forcibly married at the age of 15, she became a mother to three children, and she left Syria and eventually moved to Manchester, UK, where she enrolled at college and sought greater independence. After a short period of time, her husband showed signs of abusive behaviour, and Rania tried to divorce him to free herself from his threats of violence as well as spare her children from witnessing such traumatic life experiences. Her husband resented her willingness to defend herself and the sense of freedom she felt, which led to him luring her to a flat in Salford, Greater Manchester, where he murdered her in a pre-planned honour-based killing in June 2013 before hiding her body off the A19 in North Yorkshire. The case raised concerns about missed opportunities to protect her despite prior reports of abuse; her husband was convicted in June 2014 and sentenced to life imprisonment with a minimum term of 20 years.[34]

The confinement of Eleni Karioti

In November 1978, in Greece, Eleni Karioti was found living in confinement in her family's home in Kostalexi, reportedly after approximately 29 years. One widely circulated account attributed her confinement to a relationship with a left-wing man opposed by her royalist family, but this motive is disputed. Reports described severe psychological distress and difficulty speaking; they do not establish that confinement alone caused her condition. Accounts also describe silence within the village until an anonymous tip alerted the authorities. Her siblings were tried and acquitted, but the available reports do not establish that this resulted from legal loopholes. After hospital and psychiatric care, she reportedly returned to Kostalexi and later disappeared. Her fate remains uncertain, and the case cannot be presented as a confirmed honour-based murder.[35]

Timeline of Events

Date	Description of Event
c. 1075 BC	A surviving compilation of Middle Assyrian laws illustrates severe, unequal penalties relating to sexual conduct; some provisions also punish men.
449 BC	The Twelve Tables, composed in 451–450 BC, are traditionally said to have been ratified in 449 BC.

[34] Greater Manchester Police. (2025, February 26). Update following search for remains of Rania Alayed in Thirsk. https://www.gmp.police.uk/news/greater-manchester/news/news/2025/february/update-following-search-for-remains-of-rania-alayed-in-thirsk/

[35] Δημητρίου, Z. (2023, October 23). Κωσταλέξι: Η πραγματική ιστορία πίσω από τα 29 χρόνια εγκλεισμού της Ελένης Καρυώτη [Kostalexi: The story of Eleni Karioti's confinement]. LadyLike. https://www.ladylike.gr/life/kostalexi-i-eleni-karioti-den-itan-i-treli-tou-xoriou/

Date	Description of Event
1971	Chiswick Women's Aid, the organisation later known as Refuge, opened its first refuge in the United Kingdom.
November 1978	Eleni Karioti was found in confinement in Kostalexi, reportedly after approximately 29 years.
18 December 1979	The UN General Assembly adopted CEDAW through Resolution 34/180 and opened it for signature, ratification and accession.
1993	Karma Nirvana was established as a UK-based organisation supporting victims of honour abuse and forced marriage.
4 December 2000	The UN General Assembly adopted Resolution 55/66 to address honour-based crimes against women worldwide.
25 April 2002	Anooshe Sediq Ghulam was reportedly murdered outside a police station in Norway, highlighting risks to victims seeking protection.
June 2013	Rania Alayed was murdered in Salford by her husband in a pre-planned honour-based killing over her independence.
27 May 2014	Farzana Parveen was beaten to death with bricks by relatives near the Lahore High Court for marrying a man of her choice.
May 2020	Romina Ashrafi was killed by her father in Iran; he later received a nine-year prison sentence under provisions exempting fathers from qisas.

Major Actors Involved

United Kingdom (UK)

Honour-based abuse and killings in the United Kingdom are a serious but often hidden problem. Police in England and Wales recorded 2,949 HBA-related offences in the year ending March 2025; these figures do not support a reliable ranking against other European countries. Cases have been reported in communities of South Asian, Middle Eastern and Kurdish heritage, but the abuse is not confined to any community. In August 2025, the UK Government announced plans for a statutory definition and guidance, alongside its commitment to halve violence against women and girls. The announcement was a commitment to introduce a definition, rather than evidence that one was already in force. Proposed training for teachers, police officers, doctors and social workers aims to improve recognition of warning signs and victim protection. Despite these efforts, significant gaps

remain. Higher recorded totals can reflect reporting and recording changes and do not necessarily mean that underlying abuse has increased. Measures to identify cases also need to support prevention. Parliament has examined the issue through reports and inquiries. The Women and Equalities Committee retained the term "honour-based abuse" in its 2023 report because it reflects survivors' experiences and perpetrators' methods of control. Underreporting, difficulties bringing cases to court and uneven police responses remain concerns.[36, 37, 38, 39]

Norway

Norway has been showing dedication to minimising the total cases of honour-based abuse and killings through the creation and implementation of integration programmes. However, non-fatal forced marriages and negative social control in the diaspora communities are still being monitored. Cases such as the reported murder of Anooshe Sediq Ghulam outside a police station highlighted protection risks. Norway's first action plan against forced marriage dates to 1998; subsequent plans have also addressed negative social control and honour-based violence. Measures include the creation of a specialised expert team that is responsible for handling complex cases of honour-based abuse and forced marriage, the implementation of strict criminal penalties under the Norwegian Penal Code for cases that are of forced marriage, illegal coercion, and female genital mutilation (FGM), as well as the training of specialist counsellors who are stationed inside schools with substantial minority populations, to spot possible control signs at the earliest stage possible. The main issue that has occurred is that there are transnational abuse gaps, as relatives may attempt to evade

[36] Home Office. (2025, August 26). 'Honour'-based abuse crackdown in raft of new measures. GOV.UK. https://www.gov.uk/government/news/honour-based-abuse-crackdown-in-raft-of-new-measures
[37] Home Office. (2025, August 26). 'Honour'-based abuse crackdown in raft of new measures. GOV.UK. https://www.gov.uk/government/news/honour-based-abuse-crackdown-in-raft-of-new-measures
[38] Hall, R. (2025, August 26). UK to clarify definition of 'honour'-based abuse in drive to cut violence against women and girls. The Guardian. https://www.theguardian.com/society/2025/aug/26/uk-to-clarify-definition-of-honour-based-abuse-in-drive-to-cut-violence-against-women-and-girls
[39] Women and Equalities Committee. (2023, July 19). So-called honour-based abuse (HC 831). House of Commons. https://publications.parliament.uk/pa/cm5803/cmselect/cmwomeq/831/report.html

Norwegian law by taking the victim abroad, leading to the need for a diplomatic intervention in the situation.[40, 41, 42, 43, 44]

Iran

Honour-based violence and killings are a serious concern in Iran. Published estimates suggest hundreds of killings annually, but no reliable national total is established. Underreporting and legal leniency towards some perpetrators make the scale difficult to assess. One example is Romina Ashrafi, a teenage girl killed by her father with a sickle in 2020. For this action, the perpetrator received only a 9-year sentence in prison, due to legal exemptions protecting fathers. UN reporting in 2025 identified gaps in comprehensive protection against domestic violence; existing criminal provisions do not ensure adequate protection for those at risk. According to Article 301 of the Islamic Penal Code, fathers and paternal grandfathers are exempt from qisas (retributive punishment) if they kill their children, while in Article 630, it is stated that a husband may be exempt from punishment for killing his wife in circumstances involving adultery, subject to specific legal conditions. While the

[40] Ministry of Labour and Social Inclusion. (n.d.). Negative social control and honour based violence. Government of Norway. https://www.regjeringen.no/en/topics/immigration-and-integration/innsikt/tvangsekteskap-og-kjonnslemlestelse/id2343479/

[41] Storhaug, H. (2002, April 27). Les Anooshes historie. Dagbladet. https://www.dagbladet.no/nyheter/les-anooshes-historie/65804535

[42] Ministry of Labour and Social Inclusion. (2025). In charge of your own life: Strengthened efforts against negative social control and honour-related violence 2025–2028. Government of Norway. https://www.regjeringen.no/globalassets/departementene/aid/bilder/nyhetsbilder/2025/signering-av-ny-ia-avtale-2025/in-charge-of-your-own-life-2025-2028.pdf

[43] Ministry of Labour and Social Inclusion. (n.d.). Negative social control and honour based violence. Government of Norway. https://www.regjeringen.no/en/topics/immigration-and-integration/innsikt/tvangsekteskap-og-kjonnslemlestelse/id2343479/

[44] Ministry of Labour and Social Inclusion. (2025). In charge of your own life: Strengthened efforts against negative social control and honour-related violence 2025–2028. Government of Norway. https://www.regjeringen.no/globalassets/departementene/aid/bilder/nyhetsbilder/2025/signering-av-ny-ia-avtale-2025/in-charge-of-your-own-life-2025-2028.pdf

legal loopholes encourage the continuation of honour-based crimes, there is a lack of safe shelters, and the institutionalised gender discrimination persists.[45, 46, 47, 48, 49]

Karma Nirvana

Karma Nirvana is a UK-based organisation, founded in 1993, helping victims and survivors of honour-based abuse and violence, which provides helplines, training, and advocacy to end these abuses. The organisation is working to provide confidential and non-judgemental support in multiple languages in order to support victims and professionals through its national Honour Based Abuse Helpline, information and guidance for those at risk of forced marriage, child marriage, FGM, or other forms of HBA. They also offer training for professionals, such as police, social workers, and healthcare staff, as well as schools, with an aim of improving the understanding of HBA, raising awareness, and informing correct safeguarding actions. Additionally, the charity collects national data, conducts research, and actively campaigns for legislative reform, such as advocating for a statutory legal definition of HBA.[50, 51]

Refuge

Refuge is a well-known UK domestic abuse charity whose first refuge opened in 1971. It mobilises the public to take action, raise awareness and donate to support women and children escaping domestic violence, coercive control, and gender-based violence including HBA. What the charity achieves is that it contributes to the creation of life-saving support through a national network of safe house refuges, independent advocacy, community outreach, tech-safety support, and by running the 24-Hour Freephone National Domestic Abuse Helpline. Its goal is to help thousands of women and

[45] Human Rights Council. (2025). Situation of human rights in the Islamic Republic of Iran: Report of the Special Rapporteur (A/HRC/58/62). United Nations. https://documents.un.org/api/symbol/access?l=en&s=A%2FHRC%2F58%2F62&t=pdf

[46] NUFDI. (2024, August 2). Crime and punishment: The Islamic republic version. National Union for Democracy in Iran. https://nufdiran.org/en/post/iranwatch/crime-and-punishment-the-islamic-republic-version

[47] Human Rights Council. (2025). Situation of human rights in the Islamic Republic of Iran: Report of the Special Rapporteur (A/HRC/58/62). United Nations. https://documents.un.org/api/symbol/access?l=en&s=A%2FHRC%2F58%2F62&t=pdf

[48] Human Rights Council. (2025). Situation of human rights in the Islamic Republic of Iran: Report of the Special Rapporteur (A/HRC/58/62). United Nations. https://documents.un.org/api/symbol/access?l=en&s=A%2FHRC%2F58%2F62&t=pdf

[49] Center for Human Rights in Iran. (2025, January 6). Killed because you are a woman—Violence against women in Iran reaches new heights. Center for Human Rights in Iran. https://iranhumanrights.org/2025/01/killed-because-you-are-a-woman-violence-against-women-in-iran-reaches-new-heights/

[50] Karma Nirvana. (n.d.-a). About us. https://karmanirvana.org.uk/about/about-us/

[51] Karma Nirvana. (n.d.-c). Karma Nirvana calls for a statutory definition of honour based abuse in memory of Fawziyah Javed. https://karmanirvana.org.uk/campaigns/current-campaigns/define-hba/

their children to overcome the physical, emotional, financial, and logistical impacts of abuse and rebuild their lives, free from fear, while actively campaigning to influence government policy.[52, 53]

UN Documents and International Agreements

CEDAW (Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women)

Adopted through UN General Assembly Resolution 34/180

On 18 December 1979, the UN General Assembly adopted CEDAW through Resolution 34/180, opening the Convention for signature, ratification and accession. Often described as an international bill of rights for women, the Convention is legally binding on its States parties and requires them to eliminate discrimination, reform discriminatory laws and promote gender equality. The Convention, interpreted by the CEDAW Committee, provides a framework for addressing gender-based violence, including honour-based abuse, and for holding States accountable. The binding instrument is the Convention, rather than the General Assembly resolution adopting it. Limitations include reservations, weak domestic implementation and gaps in protection from family-based coercive control.[54, 55]

UN General Assembly Resolution 55/66 (2000)

On 4 December 2000, during its 55th session, the UN General Assembly adopted Resolution 55/66 to address crimes against women committed in the name of honour. It emphasises States' responsibilities to prevent and investigate these crimes, punish perpetrators and protect victims in accordance with their international human rights obligations. However, the resolution is non-binding and does not itself create enforceable penalties. Implementation therefore depends on national action and existing legal obligations. It helped place the issue on the international agenda and requested a report from the Secretary-General, rather than establishing a comprehensive system for tracking individual cases.[56, 57]

[52] Refuge. (n.d.). About Refuge. https://refuge.org.uk/about-refuge/

[53] Refuge. (n.d.). About Refuge. https://refuge.org.uk/about-refuge/

[54] United Nations. (1979, December 18). Convention on the elimination of all forms of discrimination against women. https://www.un.org/en/development/desa/population/migration/generalassembly/docs/globalcompact/A_RES_34_180.pdf

[55] Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women. (2017, July 26). General recommendation No. 35 on gender-based violence against women, updating general recommendation No. 19 (CEDAW/C/GC/35). United Nations. https://docs.un.org/en/CEDAW/C/GC/35

[56] United Nations General Assembly. (2000, December 4). Working towards the elimination of crimes against women committed in the name of honour (A/RES/55/66). https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/428882

[57] Amnesty International. (1999). Pakistan: Violence against women in the name of honour (ASA 33/17/99). https://www.amnesty.org/en/wp-content/uploads/2022/02/ASA330171999ENGLISH.pdf

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue

Treating HBA as a Standard Intimate Partner Violence and Relying on DASH Tools

One of the previous attempts that was implemented by public services was to handle the honour-based abuse using standard domestic violence procedures and basic DASH (Domestic Abuse, Stalking, and Honour-Based Violence) risk checklists. The aim was to create a single checklist to help police and organisations involved to quickly measure danger and send emergency help. However, assessments focused narrowly on an intimate partner can miss risks involving multiple relatives or community members. Due to this, what is highlighted is that risk checklists used without specialist judgement may miss group threats and subtle family control, potentially leading staff to underestimate danger. Checklists should therefore support, rather than replace, specialist assessment of these complex cases.[58]

Family Mediation, Reconciliation and Community Arbitration

The use of family mediation counselling and bringing in relatives to solve conflicts has also been another approach to try to solve the issue. In this way, with the aid of specialised staff, it was hoped that arguments in families would calm down and relationships would be repaired for victims not to end up homeless or cut off from their families; however, mediation can increase danger. In most of the HBA cases, the family members are the ones who engage in the exercise of violence, with one of the ways being the use of mediation to track down victims who ran away, pressure them to drop police reports, or attack them. Official forced-marriage guidance warns against family mediation and stresses the "one chance" rule: professionals may have only one opportunity to speak to a victim and save a life. They should offer appropriate protection without alerting relatives who could put the victim at risk.[59]

Awareness Campaigns that are Disconnected from Structural Legal and Economic Reform

Another significant approach to the issue has been the heavy reliance on public awareness campaigns, as well as staff training. Educating teachers, police, and social and healthcare workers is a significant step to minimising HBA and honour-based killings as it contributes greatly to breaking taboos and helping victims ask for help. While these campaigns may have successfully raised awareness and augmented the reporting of cases, they cannot on their own guarantee a decrease in the occurrences of such crimes. The reason behind this is that victims may remain stuck in the abusive environment due to the fact that there might be a lack of financial independence, legal immigration problems, or difficulty finding safe housing, as the fear of family revenge may persist. What is important to mention as well is that in order to raise awareness, multiple research studies have been used.

[58] College of Policing. (2023). Honour-based abuse: Advice for first responders. https://assets.college.police.uk/s3fs-public/2023-03/Honour-based-abuse-advice-for-first-responders.pdf

[59] Darlington Safeguarding Partnership. (2021). Honour based abuse: Protecting children and adults practice guidance. https://www.darlington-safeguarding-partnership.co.uk/media/2036/honour-based-violence-february-2021-dsp-21.pdf

Academic studies on their own can actually help in identifying the size of the issue; however, underreporting may give a misleading picture. With these studies focusing more on the cultural roots, the family pressures, and the deep emotional trauma that might be caused by HBA, it should be kept in mind that they do not by themselves reduce the number of cases.[60, 61]

Possible Solutions

Strengthening legal frameworks

To eliminate the existing legal impunity, the Member States could enact strict legal penalties for perpetrators and those who assist or incite honour-based abuse and honour-based killings. This framework can be implemented by national justice ministries, and could receive the technical support and guidance from the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), in order to mandate the judicial training academies to reform the trial and sentencing procedures as this will ensure the necessary recognition and approach to such incidents. However, a key obstacle to the implementation of such a solution might be deep-seated political resistance in non-compliant states and potential concerns over judicial independence.

Early identification and prevention

Other major problems that are highly linked with HBA and honour killings are underreporting and unnoticed warning signs. For this reason, the national education and healthcare institutions need to establish mandatory safeguarding training for frontline professionals alongside enforced school attendance tracking. With the help that can be provided through the guidelines of UNICEF and UNESCO, the creation of such a mechanism could equip teachers, healthcare staff, and police officers to identify subtle indicators such as forced marriage threats, sudden truancy, or non-consensual family surveillance, while mandatory attendance for minors could increase the detection rates. Despite that, it is important to note that financial costs may be high, as well as the risk of families withdrawing children from formal education entirely, which could still exist.

Better victim shelter facilities

The amelioration of shelter facilities can contribute significantly to solving the issue of the lack of secure housing for victims that are fleeing multi-perpetrator tracking. Due to that, national housing authorities and specialised NGOs need to expand high-security shelter networks featuring restricted-address registries, legal aid, and tech-safety planning. With the operational guidance of UN Women, this mechanism can contribute to ensuring safe isolation from perpetrators. In order for this solution

[60] Karma Nirvana. (n.d.-b). Current campaigns. https://karmanirvana.org.uk/campaigns/current-campaigns/

[61] Roycroft, K. (2024, May 8). 'Honour-based abuse' research report shines light on legal system shortfalls - metropolis. Metropolis. https://mcrmetropolis.uk/honour-based-abuse-research-report-shines-light-on-legal-system-shortfalls/

to be achieved, there are primary obstacles involving territorial sovereignty objections and long-term financial commitments, that must be overcome.

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